

Now doctors, weren't alone in ignoring the screams. Nurses often believed, some still do, that babies were merely crying because they were tied down. But, in the research of Fran Porter, cries were measured on laboratory instruments so that the intensity of pain could be objectively analyzed. Porter's studies accurately identified cries associated with crushing, clamping and cutting of the foreskin as the most painful parts of the procedure ("Neonatal Pain Cries: Effect of Circumcision on Acoustic Features and Perceived Urgency," Child Development, 1986; 57:790-802). We can no longer use other excuses for the babies' dramatic response to excruciating pain.

Scientific research has had to validate what anyone with common sense and empathy was able to recognize. In 1988, the American Medical Association finally declared the obvious: babies do feel pain.

A special article on "Pain and Its Effects in the Human Neonate and Fetus" (The New England Journal of Medicine 1987; 317:1321-9) helped to bring the issue into focus. Drs. Anand and Hickey reported on the many studies which demonstrated the physiologic changes - cardiovascular, respiratory, hormonal and metabolic - as well as the behavioral changes - simple motor responses, facial expressions, and crying - associated with pain. They reported on the complex behavioral responses seen following circumcision such as alterations in sleep-wake cycles that are indicative of prolonged stress and also the altered arousal levels.

Referring to Marshall's study, "Circumcision: Effects upon newborn behaviour" (Infant Behavioral Development 1980; 3:1-14), which recognized changed behavioral states in infants for more than 22 hours after circumcision, Anand and Hickey wrote: "...It was therefore proposed that such painful procedures may have prolonged effects on the neurologic and psychosocial development of neonates."

*NOHARMM Editor note: According to Paul S. Williamson, M.D., "The only known long-term psychologic effect of circumcision was discovered in studies of infant gender differentiation. The behavior of uncircumcised male infant seemed to be like the behavior of female infants, so what were initially thought to be male-female differences in behavior are probably accounted for by the single traumatic episode of circumcision. So the answer to the question of whether unanesthetized surgery hurts an infant is, I think, an unequivocal "Yes." ("Neonatal Circumcision: Why and How to Use a Local Anesthetic," Consultant, 1984; 67-71).*

With regard to the memory of pain in neonates and how it affects them, Anand and Hickey report, "In the short term, these behavioral changes may disrupt the adaptation of newborn infants to their postnatal environment, the development of parent-infant binding, and feeding schedules." The pain of circumcision clearly disrupts all of these. Furthermore, this violation of the physical and emotional safety and the resultant interference with normal bonding disturbs the most basic levels of trust.

"Baby's basic trust, emotional trust, in mother and the environment has been seriously compromised," said developmental neuropsychologist, Dr. James Prescott in his presentation to The First International Symposium on Circumcision (March 1-3, 1989, Anaheim, CA). "Depression sets in and that is the beginning of sociopathy and psychopathy. We talk about empathy and compassion. How can you develop empathy and compassion when you're abandoned emotionally? And that is what happens at a very deep primitive level."